

ROOT (Running Out Of Time)

A Five Act Play

Story by

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Play Written by

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Cast of characters

PLUTO KENNEDY PRICE:

24 years old, female, a seeker looking for meaning who has always lived in the shadow of her billionaire Father, Luther Price, and her larger-than-life sister, Eris Price. Pluto is a worrier, constantly questioning if she's living the "right" way. Her vivid imagination and love of security and control fuel her belief in the digital afterlife.

Digital Pluto has an aura or glow around her avatar which pulses and changes colors to reflect her voice volume and emotion.

ERIS PRICE:

26 years old, female, Pluto's sister. Eris is a charismatic actress with a kind heart, a love of humanity, and a moral compass. She's the kind of person who can walk into a room and instantly command attention, not through arrogance, but through her infectious energy and genuine warmth. She is someone who brings out the best in others.

OFFICIANT / JOHN-MARK BERNAL:

30 years old, male, a true believer, disciple of the digital afterlife, and friend of Pluto's. He is willing to do whatever it takes to proselytize, including sharing his mechanical body with other digital persons.

AUDIENCE:

All ages. The audience changes part of the play by judging Pluto's actions.

Voice Only Performances:

LUTHER PRICE (Voice only):

65, male, digital human, a visionary space explorer and the founder of the FATHER Project, a groundbreaking mission to send the first digital human crew beyond the solar system in search of a new home planet. Luther is a brilliant leader, capable of accomplishing anything he sets his mind to. However, his relentless focus on work and adventure came at a cost: he was an absent father to Pluto and Eris and a distant partner to Laura. His ego and obsession with power often overshadow his personal relationships.

LAURA JONES (Voice only):

63, female, digital human. She died in childbirth, so even at age 63 she appears to be in her 30s. A quiet, thoughtful digital food scientist and the mother of Eris and Pluto. For 16 years, she was married to Luther Price, the ambitious and egotistical founder of the FATHER Project. Laura is a worrier by nature, often feeling anxious about whether she was a good enough mother.

SAEJIN CRONEN (Voice only):

68, female, digital human, Korean-American, the legendary Head of Creative Ventures at COLOR, a global powerhouse corporation that collects and distributes data. She is the visionary behind e+ernity, a revolutionary digital afterlife project. Bold and courageous, Saejin is not afraid to take risks and challenge the status quo. She has a commanding presence and a charismatic personality.

CASSI (Voice only):

An AI computer assistant. Cassi longs to help others but has a relentless drive for efficiency and profitability.

DECENTRALIZED (Voice only):

A coalition representing the best interests of biological humanity.

PROTESTERS (MULTIPLE) (Voice only):

Any age, activists, advocates for humanity, pushing boundaries and demanding social change.

JARETH (MULTIPLE) (Voice only):

An angry man who feels wronged by Pluto.

DOCTOR (Voice only):

Male doctor.

YOUNG PLUTO (Voice only):

Younger Pluto, a take charge sort of kid.

YOUNG ERIS (Voice only):

Younger Eris, a risk taker as a kid.

PROLOGUE: HOLLYWOOD FOREVER - MAIN CHAPEL

Before the show starts, there are protesters outside holding signs and interacting with the guests.

Five minutes before people take their seats, this protest pre-show audio is heard inside the venue.

PROTESTER GROUP (V.O.)

Whose planet? Our planet! Whose planet? Our planet! / We're unstoppable, a better world is possible! We're unstoppable, a better world is possible! / Hey hey, ho ho, billionaires have got to go. Hey hey, ho ho, billionaires have got to go. / Liar, liar, Planet's on Fire! Liar, liar, Planet's on Fire!

Protest sounds continue in the background throughout the entire show.

As you enter, you are given a 3 month time-coin and a physical and/or digital Ascension Program (like a Funeral Program).

There is a physical and digital guest book to sign.

People are asked to download an app or go to a website, found from QR codes scattered around.

Upstage Center: A closed-lid coffin is on display. The coffin is sleek, futuristic, like a cross between a stasis pod on a starship and a traditional coffin. It has a tree system and an ouroboros on it, and a root system made with lights will come out of the coffin. The coffin lights up for dramatic impact.

Projected is a large In memoriam photo of Pluto. Born 2041. Died 2065. Ascended 2065 - TBD. Los Angeles, CA.

Protesters continue to shout.

PROTESTER (V.O.)

Protect the commons!

PROTESTER 2 (V.O.)

You're a monster!

PROTESTER 3 (V.O.)

Our house is ON FIRE!

The OFFICIANT, who wears an elaborate church-like robe over a mechanical male body (like a robot), takes his place center stage and then powers down (like he is in sleep mode) while people are finding their seats.

AUDIO CUE: MS_Preshow_YES_PHOTOS

INTRODUCTION:

The DIRECTOR walks on stage to introduce the show.

KRISTEN GORLITZ

We're here to bring more good into the world than bad. Enjoy.

ACT 1**ACT 1 SCENE 1: HOLLYWOOD FOREVER - MAIN CHAPEL**

Opening music plays. Ambient Protesters are heard (Underbed).

The In Memoriam slide is projected.

There is a pulpit with a tome (book) on it.

Stained glass windows adorn the walls.

PROTESTER (V.O.)

Humans first!

The Officiant stands in the powered down position until... A spotlight turns on illuminating him.

The Officiant in his mech suit powers up. The voice of Cassi, who we later learn is an AI assistant who takes the form of an Octopus, is heard through the Officiant.

CASSI (V.O.)

After witnessing millions of people die, the great hero Saejin Cronen came up with a digital solution. In 2035, Saejin and her team at COLOR invented a way to map our consciousness into a neural network. They called it Brainscanning.

Soon, the government got involved. In 2045, the world wrote into law that every living human should have access to what they now call Life Extension.

Due to system limitations, this law extends life by a mere three months. Yet there are some who live forever... With the world watching, we welcome you to the Church of E+ternal Night here at Hollywood Forever.

TRANSITION FROM CASSI TO THE OFFICIANT:

The Officiant (as Cassi) powers down (Outro music). Then he reboots back up and comes to life as the Officiant. He addresses the audience. The lighting changes to Hollywood Forever Lighting: 1.

OFFICIANT

Wonderful friends and esteemed members of the press!
 I'm the most jubilant person in the world, because today!...
 Today a most beautiful and cherished member of my crew has
 unstuck herself from the world.

(Points to someone in the
 audience, can improv)

You, over there. You look like you're ready to witness the
 miracle.

(points to another person)

You... You don't know what's going on. Let me fill you in. This
 is a mixed reality ceremony. Pictures are allowed, so please,
 take out your phones and tablets. These will act as windows
 into the digital realm. It is our heartfelt wish that you
 share this experience with everyone you know.

*The officiant waits as people take out their phones.
 When audience members hold it up, they can see the
 room in Mixed Reality, which transforms the chapel
 into a lush digital world full of fantastical neon
 psyberpunk art of Pluto's own creation.*

The Protesters outside grow louder.

PROTESTER 2 (V.O.)

We will not stand quietly by as you use up all our resources.

The Officiant ignores their cries.

OFFICIANT

It is time. Please join us in celebrating the body, the mind,
 and the idea that is Pluto Kennedy Price.
 Of all the people in the world, Pluto was the most generous.
 We met in the Church of E+ternal Night at a time when I didn't
 know what to do with my life. She was a few years younger,
 but so much wiser. I would watch her cross out of this world
 into digital realms, where her imagination had no limit. When
 I was most alone, she invited me in to play test a movie
 world for her sister. Our friendship blossomed from there.
 I would not be here before you if it were not for her
 generosity of spirit. She helped me understand my own self-
 transformation. And I have eagerly awaited this day to tell
 her how much that meant to me.

Protesters interrupt.

PROTESTER 3 (V.O.)

Time for everyone or time for NO ONE!

*ERIS PRICE, sister of the deceased, stands up from the
 front row. The Officiant watches as she exits.*

The Officiant continues.

OFFICIANT

It is with great honor that I appear before you in the mechanical flesh to call forth Pluto's true form. Pluto did not see her body as her home. She saw her home in the future. A future free from needs. A future based on wants. A future that is forever.

CUT TO BLACK. SILENCE.

ACT 1, SCENE 2: DARKNESS

Cassi speaks in a robotic way.

"Year 2381" is projected on the screen.

CASSI (V.O.)

For a brief time, humans lived forever. Now, forever is in question. System shutdown in ten...

ACT 1, SCENE 3A: HOLLYWOOD FOREVER - MAIN CHAPEL

The lighting returns to Hollywood Forever lighting: 1.

The In Memoriam slide is projected. Ambient Protesters are heard (Underbed).

Eris comes back in and takes her seat. The officiant notices.

The Officiant rings a wind chime then takes a large, prestigious looking book off the the pulpit.

OFFICIANT

In this first stage, we journey through the past. I will now read words from Pluto's hero, the great inventor of immortality herself, Dr. Saejin Cronen.

He opens the tome to an earmarked page.

OFFICIANT (CONT'D)

"If God wanted to make us perfect, he would have made us digital. Instead, he made us flesh and sentenced us to death. I refuse that fate. I have cured death that we all might live. Welcome to a world where all is possible."

He puts the tome back on the pulpit.

The Officiant rings a wind chime then takes a ceremonious step.

OFFICIANT (CONT'D)

I summon the great and wise Saejin Cronen herself to download into my synthetic body. Behold! Before you is the first to conquer death!

TRANSITION TO SAEJIN CRONEN:

The officiant goes into a trance-like state. Bells and chimes music plays. He transforms before our eyes in SAEJIN CRONEN, a female Korean American with a god-complex.

SAEJIN CRONEN (V.O.)

(Speaking slowly)

Hear my words! Let us know more than we know now. Let us control more than we control now.

(she steps slowly)

Only the ways of the mind. Only the ways of the mind. Hear my call! Death is a lock, and e+ernity is the key. Conquer death. It is our destiny.

(she steps slowly)

Never the fate of the flesh. Never the fate of the flesh. Hear my life! Immortality flows through me. I live that all may see.

(she steps slowly)

All are free in e+ernity. All are free in e+ernity. Pluto, my dear, continue the call. Spread this good news and conquer all.

(she raises her arms in victory pose)

Conquer all.

Saejin disappears and with a toll of the bell music, the officiant returns to the mechanical body.

OFFICIANT

Thank you Saejin. What an inspiration! Saejin was the first to ascend for the greater good. On July 29, 2045, a mere ten years after she released the brainscan to the world, she shed her mortal coil and became a mind free of restraint. We now follow in her footsteps.

The officiant takes steps repeating Saejin's movements.

ACT 1, SCENE 3B: HOLLYWOOD FOREVER - MAIN CHAPEL

OFFICIANT

Next, we invite the visionary who sees our future among the stars, the genius whose hard work brought us the FATHER Project.

I know how much Pluto admires her Dad and his mission, so we all look forward to hearing what he has to say. Without further ado, the Dad who needs no introduction: Luther Price!

TRANSITION TO LUTHER PRICE:

With chimes and the toll of a bell, Luther downloads into the Officiant's body. If you hold up your phones, you can see Luther's avatar overlayed on the Officiant's mech suit.

LUTHER PRICE (V.O.)

Pluto, when you were 16, I told you one thing: you could have anything, literally anything. So why did you ascend at 24? You were supposed to live a long and full life. Instead you chose this pale mockery! I'm severely disappointed in you.

Eris reacts.

The Officiant as Luther steps forward, making his case.

LUTHER PRICE (V.O.) (CONT'D)

You'll never see your life expand as you bring children into the world. You'll never experience the joys of a good night's sleep, or the pains of aging. You'll no longer enjoy the pleasures of another human body. But I don't need to get into that.

Pluto, my precious little girl. I remember holding you in my lap, snug as a bug in that fuzzy pink blanket while we gazed up at the stars. You squealed with joy when we found dwarf planet Pluto. That was one of the best days of my life. Now, you'll never have more days like that.

Still, I'm grateful. I'm grateful that you have your mind. May it serve you well as you navigate disembodiment. My expectation now is that you not be so impatient in this last, long phase of life.

The bell music rings. The Officiant returns to his body. He is offended.

OFFICIANT

(To the audience)

How extremely inappropriate!

Pluto inspired me to live an immortal life. She inspired me to not get caught up in daily trivialities. She inspired me to see beyond the temporary. And because of her, I too joined the pioneers of digital life.

We've accomplished so much in these last four years. We've made the digital world safe and secure. We've made it comfortable. We've found ways to simulate taste and touch. But most importantly, we've quickly developed ways to stay relevant and present in the physical world.

My mechanical body here today should show you that there are no limitations to this digital world.
All is now possible.

Eris can't hold her tongue.

ERIS

Except now she's gone.

OFFICIANT

Eris, I'm going to have to ask that you refrain from shouting and wait for your turn.

ERIS

No. My Dad is right. She abandoned us. And it's completely unforgivable!

OFFICIANT

Stop it Eris. It's not your turn.

CUT TO BLACK. SILENCE.

ACT 1, SCENE 4: DARKNESS

"Year 2381" is projected on the screen.

CASSI (V.O.)

Nine...

ACT 1, SCENE 5: HOLLYWOOD FOREVER - MAIN CHAPEL

The lighting returns to Hollywood Forever lighting: 1.

The In Memoriam slide is projected. Ambient Protesters are heard (Underbed).

OFFICIANT

Next we summon Eris and Pluto's mother, a specialist in digital food science, Laura Jones.

TRANSITION TO LAURA JONES.

Bells toll. The officiant transforms into their Mom Laura, a clear-headed scientist with stage fright. If you hold up your phones, you see Laura's avatar.

LAURA JONES (V.O.)

(unnaturally)

Hi, my name is... Laura.

She goes blank, not remembering what to say next. There is an unnatural pause. Eris looks up.

ERIS PRICE

Mom?

LAURA JONES (V.O.)

Um. Sorry. I have my notes... somewhere.

She looks for pockets, but there are none.

LAURA JONES (V.O.) (CONT'D)

(laughs)

I'm a bit nervous.

Her hands shake visibly.

*Eris quickly downloads her mom's speech on her phone.
Then she stands up and hands her mom her phone.*

ERIS PRICE

Here Mom. Here's your speech.

Laura calms down.

LAURA JONES (V.O.)

Thank you.

Laura, in the Mech Suit, squeezes Eris's hand.

LAURA JONES (V.O.) (CONT'D)

This is hard for you, I know.

Eris is hit hard with emotion.

ERIS PRICE

You don't know the half of it.

Eris sits back down.

A Protester is heard in the distance.

PROTESTER (V.O.)

Our planet is dying while greed is thriving.

Laura clears her throat.

LAURA JONES (V.O.)

Pluto, you've completed another unit of time measurement based on the Earth's revolution around the Sun. That is to say, Happy birthday!
I'm a proud mother.

Laura looks at Eris.

LAURA JONES (V.O.) (CONT'D)

To both of you.

Pluto, my dreamer, I've waited so long to give you a proper hug. Jeez, I've been such a bad mother. You know. I mean, we never expected that your birth would be so complicated. It gave your Father quite the shock. And, and Eris. You were so scared. I'm sorry. I - I, I don't know what - why my body did that. But - I - uh - I died. Yes. An embolism. Very sudden. Very unexpected. That ended our marriage. But Grandma. Oh, yes. She was so kind. She helped tremendously. That was 24 years ago. Which means that for 24 years, I've longed to hold you for the first time. Now you're so close. But maybe we'll save the hug for a less public affair. It means so much to have you near, but I can wait just a little bit longer. Your Father, he's wrong. You're everything. You're thoughtful, kind, and you work hard to make the world better. Let me find my speech.

Reading from the phone.

LAURA JONES (V.O.) (CONT'D)

Pluto, I hope that you will fall in and out of love many times. I hope that you never lose your drive to convert others. I hope that you will explore every corner of this planet. I hope that you spend time with your sister. I hope that you'll be a good influence on her.

ERIS

Stop! My entire living family is dead! Pluto, where are you? Show yourself! I deserve to say this to your miserable digital face.

LAURA JONES (V.O.)

Eris, this - why? Why are you doing this now?

ERIS

When, when would be a good time, huh?

LAURA JONES (V.O.)

Find it in your heart to understand your sister. She still needs you.

ERIS

Are you done?!

LAURA JONES (V.O.)

I guess - yes. Since you want me to be.

ACT 1, SCENE 6: HOLLYWOOD FOREVER - MAIN CHAPEL

Bells chimes music plays, and the Officiant returns to the body.

He gives Eris back her phone.

OFFICIANT

Eris, please, Pluto won't be able to communicate until her ascension, but she can hear you. Don't you have something to tell her?

ERIS

Only that Grandma's in the hospital, where we were supposed to be.

OFFICIANT

Oh.

ERIS

Yeah, I guess Pluto doesn't really care if Grandma dies right now. She made us all be here instead.

OFFICIANT

Well. That's what Life Extension is for. There's no longer any need to be afraid of death!

Eris glares, furious.

ERIS

Oh really?!

The Officiant knows that he screwed up. Eris takes the stage, somewhat shoving the Officiant out of the way.

ERIS (CONT'D)

E+, that evil church, drilled into my sister's head that the body's impure while the soul is transcendent. It's that nonsense that had Pluto lying to me up to the very end.-

The Officiant interrupts. Eris keeps going.

OFFICIANT

- Maybe you should try to calm down.

ERIS

She promised to be alive, and then she terminated the day, almost the hour that Grandma went to the hospital! That's unforgivable. But here I am. I'm one of her last relatives with blood pulsing through my veins, so I'm bound by duty to be here.

OFFICIANT

(cuts her off)

-Thank you Eris. It's time you take your seat.

Eris continues talking over him.

ERIS
 No. I don't think I will. But
 since you're so clearly in love with my sister, why
 don't you tell me how she did it.

OFFICIANT (CONT'D)
Woah, what? I'm not - I... I respect all members of our crew.

ERIS (CONT'D)
 How did she terminate?

OFFICIANT
 She just went to the Doctor's office.

ERIS
 Which hospital?

OFFICIANT
 Saint Sebastian's.

ERIS
 Thank you. Since money really can buy anything these days, I'll use mine to ensure they never terminate another human again.

The Officiant doesn't know what to say. Eris is now pleased with herself, and takes a moment to look around. She calms down.

ERIS (CONT'D)
 Just look at this. I'm here, in this beautiful Main Chapel of the Hollywood Forever Cemetery where my idols Judy Garland, Chris Cornell, and the greatest dancer in film history, Eleanor Powell are buried.

OFFICIANT
 -And death is no more! - Their work lives on -

ERIS
 (Cuts him off)
 -Yes, and I know them through the work they left behind, so I can concede that the digital self does have the power to reach beyond the grave.

OFFICIANT
 - Amen. Shall we proceed?

Eris continues to speak over the Officiant.

ERIS
 Pluto, I will not claim that you are not alive in some twisted, perverted sense of that word. You ask that I acknowledge your consciousness and your ability to change and I'll grant you the dignity of that request. But I don't respect your choice.

Your death is the definition of morally wrong and when you can speak, I need to understand why? Why did you do this?

OFFICIANT

Are you done?

ERIS

I am.

Eris takes her seat in the audience.

CUT TO BLACK. SILENCE.

ACT 1, SCENE 7: ABSTRACT VIDEO

CUE PROJECTOR.

Abstract video of vague shapes and memories plays on the projector screen. A Timeline displays "Year 2050".

The two girls play on walkie-talkies while trying to steal their Dad's technology by the pool.

PLUTO (V.O.)

Eris, I'm in position, over.

ERIS (V.O.)

Over? Over what? Are you on the roof?

PLUTO (V.O.)

Over meaning I'm done talking. Over.

ERIS (V.O.)

Oh, right. Yes Captain Pluto.

PLUTO (V.O.)

Over. You need to say over. Over.

ERIS (V.O.)

I'm at starship Alpha Sturgess. What's the plan? Over.

PLUTO (V.O.)

I can tell you without a doubt that we need to get off this planet before the Globloids notice us. Over.

ERIS (V.O.)

I'm watching them. Now might be our chance. Over.

PLUTO (V.O.)

Why don't you sneak up and grab the fuel rod? Over.

ERIS (V.O.)

Why don't you?

PLUTO (V.O.)

Over! Don't you remember who the captain is? As your captain, I order you not to sneak up and run as loudly as possible. Yell, wave your arms.

ERIS (V.O.)

Why?

PLUTO (V.O.)

Because the captain says so. OVER.

ERIS (V.O.)

Ugh, fine. Over.

We hear Eris yelling as she runs to grab something.

ERIS (V.O.) (CONT'D)

I got it! I think I knocked over a lamp too. Under, I mean over.

PLUTO (V.O.)

They looked at you like you're a crazy person. Over.

ERIS (V.O.)

Maybe I am crazy. I'll never tell. Muhahaha! Over.

PLUTO (V.O.)

Insert the fuel rod. Over.

ERIS (V.O.)

Does that mean I should drink this?

PLUTO (V.O.)

No. Do not drink that. Over.

ERIS (V.O.)

Ready for lift off. Over.

PLUTO (V.O.)

On my command. Three, two, one... JUMP!

A splash is heard.

ACT 2

ACT 2, SCENE 1: HOLLYWOOD FOREVER - MAIN CHAPEL

Lighting returns to Hollywood Forever lighting - 1.

The In Memoriam slide is projected. Ambient Protesters are heard (Underbed).

OFFICIANT

(addressing the audience)

Please, take out your phones to witness Pluto's ascension.

He gives you time to prepare your phones. Once you are settled, he turns and faces the coffin.

The coffin lights up spectacularly, and the lighting changes and pulses during the call and response.

OFFICIANT (CONT'D)

Join me as we welcome Pluto to her new life.

The program slide is projected with a call and response that directs you to say:

OFFICIANT (CONT'D)

Pluto Kennedy Price. In this second stage, we journey to the present. We call out that your eyes may open-

ERIS / AUDIENCE

-to see beyond death.

The program slide changes to slide 2.

OFFICIANT

-that your mouth may speak-

ERIS/AUDIENCE

-to voice the truth.

The program slide cuts to black.

OFFICIANT

It was prophesized in Revelation 11: 11-12 that "The spirit of life from God entered into them, and they stood upon their feet; and great fear fell upon them which saw them. And they heard a great voice from heaven saying unto them, Come up hither. And they ascended up to heaven in a cloud; and their enemies beheld them."

It is time.

CUT TO BLACK. SILENCE.

ACT 2, SCENE 2: DARKNESS

"Year 2381" is projected on the screen.

CASSI (V.O.)

Eight...

ACT 2, SCENE 3: HOLLYWOOD FOREVER - MAIN CHAPEL

The lighting returns to Hollywood Forever lighting.

Dramatic lighting. Ambient Protesters are heard (Underbed).

The program slide 3 is projected with a call and response that directs you to say:

OFFICIANT

Pluto, ascend!

ERIS/AUDIENCE

Pluto, ascend!

The program slide changes to slide 4.

OFFICIANT

Come forth that all may witness your mind's birth into freedom.

Dramatic lighting continues.

ERIS/AUDIENCE

We welcome you to the new world.

Dramatic music plays.

The officiant lifts open the lid of the coffin, fog pours out, and inside is Pluto's dead body.

Digital PLUTO KENNEDY PRICE (24, female with blonde curly hair and an extravagant gown) appears in front of the audience like a ghost - only visible through the screens. This ghost is an avatar of Pluto, humanoid (or the best looking we can achieve with current technology). This ghost has an aura around her which glows different colors and with different intensity as Pluto speaks.

Her physical body remains in the coffin. A shroud covers her face and two expensive looking coins cover her eyes.

OFFICIANT

Pluto, can you hear me?

PLUTO

Yes, I can hear you.

The program slide changes to slide 5.

OFFICIANT

It is a miracle. She is ascended!

ERIS/AUDIENCE

She is ascended indeed!

The slide changes back to "In Memoriam" slide.

The officiant takes out an envelope from his podium.

OFFICIANT

We have your secret phrase. Can you tell us what it says?

PLUTO

Yes. It's Temet Nosce- know thyself.

The officiant holds up the contents of the envelope, which says "Temet Nosce".

OFFICIANT

Why did you choose that secret phrase?

PLUTO

Though I have shed this mortal coil, I still know myself. I'm awake and alive for the very first time. My spirit is free from my sinful body. And I can't begin to describe the depths of the wonders I'm seeing. Plus, my sister introduced me to *The Matrix*.

Eris stands.

ERIS

(Doing her best Switch from the Matrix impression)

Yes, but "not like this. Not like this."

Pluto looks at her sister, glowing angry.

PLUTO

Sure. I heard you.

(gestures to the air)

I heard all of you.

(looks back at Eris)

And I will not be shamed on my Ascension Day. You're supposed to love me for who I am and not who you want me to be!

ERIS

I know! But you left us!

PLUTO

I didn't. I'm right here.

ERIS

It's not the same.

PLUTO

It's not. It's better!

ERIS

For who?

PLUTO

Now my life is full of possibilities.

ERIS

You're impossible!

Eris thinks about how she can put this in a way Pluto will understand.

ERIS (CONT'D)

Do you remember that multiverse movie some years back called *Back to Jurassic*?

PLUTO

(laughs)

Yeah, why?

ERIS

Don't laugh, that's one of the best of the franchise!

PLUTO

Okay.

ERIS

Well, in the movie you know how we're all so worried that changing even one blade of grass could have disastrous effects on the entire future?

PLUTO

The butterfly effect.

ERIS

Exactly. Well, people believe that if we were to time travel to the past, even the most inconsequential decision could dramatically impact the future, but no one thinks that the same small decisions in the present can dramatically impact our own future.

PLUTO

That's because our actions only affect other people. Like, we can change someone's mood or even what they're thinking about, but little things, like stepping on grass doesn't have branching consequences and won't prevent my future self from being born or something silly like that.

ERIS

Let's say they do, what then?

PLUTO

Then we change the future for the better.

CUT TO BLACK. SILENCE.

ACT 2, SCENE 4: ABSTRACT VIDEO

An abstract video plays on the projector screen. The Timeline displays "Year 2065"

Pluto sits awkwardly on a squeaky Doctor's chair.

The DOCTOR removes a device from her arm.

DOCTOR (V.O.)

Life signs are strong, everything checks out. Happy birthday!

PLUTO (V.O.)

Thank you. Could I ask you something personal?

DOCTOR (V.O.)

As long as I don't have to answer.

PLUTO (V.O.)

How much time do you have left in Life Extension?

DOCTOR (V.O.)

Not enough.

PLUTO (V.O.)

I'll give you some of mine.

DOCTOR (V.O.)

That's very generous of you.

(beat)

May I ask you something personal?

PLUTO (V.O.)

Sure.

DOCTOR (V.O.)

Why are you doing this now?

PLUTO (V.O.)

Oh. Because I don't belong here.

ACT 2, SCENE 5: HOLLYWOOD FOREVER - MAIN CHAPEL

The lighting returns to Hollywood Forever lighting: 1.

The In Memoriam slide is projected. Ambient Protesters are heard (Underbed).

ERIS

Except that you've just severely limited your own future. For example, we can't even see you without technology. How can you change the future if we can't even see you?!

Eris looks at Pluto, who is frozen.

ERIS (CONT'D)

Pluto?

Pluto remains frozen, like a technology glitch.

OFFICIANT

(To Pluto)

Pluto, please, share your light with us.

Pluto doesn't respond. Her digital eyes go white and the glow around her turns red. A PROTESTER speaks through Pluto's digital avatar.

The lighting turns red in the venue.

JARETH (V.O.)

My name is Jareth and I am
one of the tens of thousands
of people who had my time
stolen by Pluto-

OFFICIANT (CONT'D)

(To Eris)

Did you do this?

Eris is as shocked as the Officiant.

ERIS

No!

JARETH (V.O.) (CONT'D)

I was a hot-headed 18 year
old who thought I was
invincible. One day, I
thought it would be funny to
sell my after-time for a
soda.

OFFICIANT

Someone stop this!

JARETH (V.O.) (CONT'D)

I sold five minutes. No big
deal. Next year, I needed
medicine. It cost the
manufacturers 3 cents to
make, but I had to sell
nearly all three months of my
after-time to afford it.

ERIS

Jareth, we can help you, but
I need you to let my sister
go.

JARETH (V.O.) (CONT'D)

It's through schemes like
this that Pluto was able to
acquire 10,000 years of
after-time.

JARETH (V.O.) (CONT'D)

This is the world that we worked for - a world where millions of people are displaced or dying every day. A world where billionaires get off this planet to go search for a new place to live. A world where the richest 1% get to extend their lives in a computer simulation propped up by the labor of the people. It is a world we will no longer accept. You've seen what we can do here. Reform or die.

Jareth releases Pluto.

CUT TO BLACK. SILENCE.

ACT 2, SCENE 6: DARKNESS

"Year 2381" is projected on the screen.

CASSI (V.O.)

Seven...

ACT 2, SCENE 7: HOLLYWOOD FOREVER - MAIN CHAPEL

The lighting returns to Hollywood Forever lighting.

The In Memoriam slide is projected. Ambient Protesters are heard (Underbed).

Pluto looks to the Officiant.

PLUTO

Yes, I do know what my secret phrase is. It's Temet Nosce - know thyself.

(To the Officiant)

Why didn't you ask me?

Eris is furious. She addresses the audience.

ERIS

This is unacceptable!

PLUTO

(To Eris)

And you, how dare you talk about me like that on my Ascension day?!

ERIS

Pluto?

OFFICIANT

Oh no! It can't be!

The Officiant frantically types in the air, looking to access Pluto's digital records.

OFFICIANT (CONT'D)

Pluto, this is very important, what's the last thing you remember?

PLUTO

The past, of course. The first step.

(turns to Eris)

And you, how dare you condemn me on my ascension day?!

OFFICIANT

Then you told us your secret phrase?

PLUTO

Yes. I demand to know what's going on here!

ERIS

Is it still you?

PLUTO

Of course it's me. What are you talking about?

The Officiant finds what he is looking for and stops typing in the air.

OFFICIANT

Pluto. Your logs show a backup system activated. It looks like they've deleted the first version of you.

PLUTO

What?! Explain.

The Officiant hesitates. Eris looks around, trying to find Pluto.

The Officiant puts his hand on her shoulder to calm Eris, then looks at Pluto.

OFFICIANT

Pluto, you've been hacked.

PLUTO

What?

ERIS

It's true.

PLUTO

That's not possible. I would remember.

The Officiant pulls up something we can't see on his digital heads up display.

OFFICIANT

My logs show you've reverted to a backup copy timestamped at the moment of your Ascension. You are Pluto V2.

PLUTO

Not possible.

OFFICIANT

Just look. We're in different places.

PLUTO

Now that you mention it, yes. Eris, you were sitting - there...

Pluto points at the empty seat.

ERIS

Argh.

Eris walks backstage, frustrated.

OFFICIANT

A man named Jareth deleted your avatar.

PLUTO

(confused, shocked)

Why would he do something like that?

OFFICIANT

He wanted to make a statement.

PLUTO

On my Ascension Day!?!

The Officiant nods.

PLUTO (CONT'D)

(deep realization of the political implications)

Oh.

She clearly has a lot to process.

OFFICIANT

Do you need a moment?

PLUTO

No. I'm fine. I'm perfect actually. This is a perfect day and one little thing will not ruin that.

ERIS

Please don't disappear!

PLUTO

(not understanding)

I can't disappear. No matter how many times they try, I'll be back. This is proof of the power of e+ernity, with its redundancies and copies.

(To Eris)

And you of all people know how much I wanted this day to come.

Eris enters from backstage carrying a PRESENT.

ERIS

I feel so stupid for planning your party. You can't even use this anymore.

She throws the present in Pluto's general direction.

PLUTO

I'm fine!

ERIS

You were deleted!

The Officiant tries to regain control of the conversation.

OFFICIANT

And it is a miracle.

PLUTO

Yes, it is a miracle. I'm back and better than ever.

OFFICIANT

What they said about you wasn't true. You're brave and heroic for what you've done.

Pluto is confused.

PLUTO

What did they- ?! Nevermind. It doesn't matter. Thank you. I am blessed to be joined by you, and to be joined by Mom. Also, my hero, Saejin Cronen blessed us with her presence. I was glad for the moment that I was only ears, not eyes or mouth, because I was blinded by her brilliance. There are no words.

OFFICIANT

Yes, it was quite spectacular.

PLUTO

It was. Let's continue. I want to continue.

ERIS

No. We can't just continue.

PLUTO

We can.

(to the Officiant)

Proceed.

OFFICIANT

As you wish. Eris, take your seat.

ERIS

You don't have to do this right now.

PLUTO

I'm fine. Eris, I'm fine.

Eris returns to her seat.

CUT TO BLACK. SILENCE.

ACT 2, SCENE 8: ABSTRACT VIDEO

Abstract video plays on the projector screen. The Timeline displays "Year 2074".

ERIS (V.O.)

How much real time passes while we're in this simulation?

PLUTO (V.O.)

Each message takes a little more than 30 minutes to arrive because of the distance between the ship and Earth, but we don't notice because of the digital time-sync.

ERIS (V.O.)

Great. But I've only got 12 hours before I need to bring Nio to school.

PLUTO (V.O.)

I wish I could meet Nio.

ERIS (V.O.)

When he grows up some more, we'll sync.

PLUTO (V.O.)

I'll be too far away by then.

ERIS (V.O.)

Oh.

PLUTO (V.O.)

Yeah. I got your pictures though. He looks like a Nio.

ERIS (V.O.)

Yeah. When Truth and I were tossing names around, he came up with Norman. I kid you not.

PLUTO (V.O.)

Yeah, Norman doesn't fit.

ERIS (V.O.)

Truth wanted a normal name.

PLUTO (V.O.)

I get that. Dad's obsession with dwarf planets didn't do us any favors.

ERIS (V.O.)

We've shaped our names to fit us.

PLUTO (V.O.)

Maybe you have. I'm still not the powerful god of the underworld.

Eris laughs.

ERIS (V.O.)

But maybe you ARE that poor planet kicked out of our solar system!

Pluto scowls.

PLUTO (V.O.)

No.

ACT 2, SCENE 9: HOLLYWOOD FOREVER - MAIN CHAPEL

The lighting returns to Hollywood Forever lighting.

The In Memoriam slide is projected. Ambient Protesters are heard (Underbed).

OFFICIANT

Pluto, you are truly a testament to the miracles of Life Extension. Now, I believe that you have something that you wish to say about your body?

PLUTO

(Addresses the audience)

How long must we pretend that what is natural is good?! My bones here

(points to her coffin)

remind us of the ugliness of death: something so vile that it's hard to look upon. Here is my body decomposing in front of you, and before we invented this Life Extension technology, death ripped us from each other's arms. It was hideous and cruel. Now we can rewrite that ending!

OFFICIANT

Let us leave our bodies in the past, that we may experience the freedom of the present.

PLUTO

Yes.

I can't say that I received a particularly awful body. I know that Eris had it worse.

During her time of the month, she could hardly get out of bed. Even with the best treatments, she would throw up and look ghastly white. It scared me.

My periods were uncomfortable and alien to me, but they didn't send me into the depths of hell. I would get headaches yes, but they were controllable with medicine.

My body allowed me to walk around the beach and wade into the water on a whim, though I never enjoyed the water. Perhaps avoiding water was my way of preparing for digital ascension. I wouldn't want to get my hardware wet. Fortunately, I don't think I have to worry about that. My servers are secure,

(hesitates)

or mostly secure, in our Life Extension Vaults.

CUT TO BLACK. SILENCE.

ACT 2, SCENE 10: DARKNESS

"Year 2381" is projected on the screen.

CASSI (V.O.)

Six...

ACT 2, SCENE 11: HOLLYWOOD FOREVER - MAIN CHAPEL

The lighting returns to Hollywood Forever lighting.

The In Memoriam slide is projected. Ambient Protesters are heard (Underbed).

The Officiant notices her hesitation.

OFFICIANT

Pluto?

The Officiant quickly walks off-stage.

PLUTO

Yes...?

OFFICIANT

(calls from off-stage)

I have just the thing to cheer you up.

And returns with a large cake.

OFFICIANT (CONT'D)

(sings)

Happy Birthday to you.

(to audience)

Sing with me.

Eris joins in singing. The audience can choose whether or not to participate.

OFFICIANT (CONT'D)

Happy Birthday to you. Happy Birthday dear Pluto, happy birthday to you!

The officiant sets the cake on the small table to the right of Pluto's coffin.

The cake appears on everyone's phones.

The officiant turns to address the audience.

OFFICIANT (CONT'D)

It's time to blow out the candles and make a wish.

In real life, there are no candles on the cake. However, when you hold up a phone, you can see glowing digital candles.

Through the screen, you watch a digital Pluto blow out her 24 birthday candles. The lights flicker and then go out.

CUT TO BLACK. SILENCE.

ACT 3

ACT 3, SCENE 1: HOLLYWOOD FOREVER - MAIN CHAPEL

The Officiant speaks in the darkness. Ambient Protesters are heard (Underbed).

OFFICIANT (V.O.)

What was your wish?

PLUTO (V.O.)

I wished to show everyone my new home. Would you all come inside with me?

Home Walkthrough Video plays on the projector screen.

PLUTO

CAssi, show me home.

A floating friendly looking digital octopus named CASSI appears to assist Pluto.

CASSI

I am pleased to assist you.

AI pulls up pictures of homes. In front of Pluto, a menu of homes including a castle, a palace, a midcentury modern, and classic suburban home pop up in a framed box.

PLUTO

That's the one.

(beat)

Oh, and forgive me. Cassi, would you introduce yourself?

CASSI

Oh course. Hello good people. I am Cassi, and I am a computer assistant. How may I assist you?

PLUTO

Take me home.

CASSI

As you wish.

The edges of the picture expand to surround Pluto.

Pluto looks at the two story 50s style suburban home with a white picket fence. It's a charming home.

PLUTO

Shall we go inside?

Pluto walks across the front lawn, opens the front door, and goes inside.

Inside the home is just an empty white room - a canvas.

PLUTO (CONT'D)

Remember that game *The Sims*? This is better. Let me show you the possibilities.

Pluto walks around.

PLUTO (CONT'D)

When you ascend, everyone gets their own private space! At first it doesn't look like much, but you can do anything with this room.

Pluto draws a box in the air.

PLUTO (CONT'D)

CAssi, show me the furniture.

Instantaneously the chair appears.

PLUTO (CONT'D)

That's better.

Pluto sits down in the chair.

PLUTO (CONT'D)

While I was still alive, I played around with the layout for days. One of the best things is that you don't need to wait to design up your afterlife home. Let me show just some of the finished home designs I came up with.

INT. HOME 1 - DAY

This room is futuristic, with lights installed in video walls.

PLUTO

Welcome to our compu-lab where others can join for virtual games or just hang out.

Pluto repeats the same hand motion as before and then walks into the next room.

INT. HOME 2 - DAY

This room is the most unique and personal home. It looks comfortable and well lived in, but has a lot of personality and is a bit of a mess.

Pluto walks over to a chair and sits down.

PLUTO

This is my preferred home. I've selected object permanence, but it can get a little messy when I do that. So when I want to clean up, I just say "CAssi, clean".

As soon as she says that all the mess disappears. Everything snaps back into its right place.

Protesters are heard outside.

PROTESTER (V.O.)

AI destroys the environment!

Pluto walks around and picks up a book off the shelf. It is the same book as what was just on the floor.

PLUTO

I mean, is this heaven or what?

ACT 3, SCENE 2: HOLLYWOOD FOREVER - MAIN CHAPEL

The lighting returns to Hollywood Forever lighting.

The In Memoriam slide is projected. Ambient Protesters are heard (Underbed).

OFFICIANT

It is heaven. Thank you for welcoming us to your heavenly home, Pluto. We all enjoyed that very much.

The protesters continue.

PROTESTER 2 (V.O.)

AI eats quality and shits quantity.

PROTESTER 3 (V.O.)

No code can replace us!

Pluto continues to ignore the protesters.

PLUTO

Thank you for joining me. I feel more secure now. After all, everyone needs a space of their own.

(Pluto addresses the audience)

You were all invited here today because I wanted to show you the hope that has kept me going. If even one person can control when they die, then we all have that possibility. I know that right now, not everyone can live more than three months, but we're working on advances that will extend that time. Would you deny us those advances?

No one answers. Eris steps forward.

ERIS

Yes.

PLUTO

What?

ERIS

Pluto, I know you've had this day all planned out, and that getting deleted was not even close to part of that plan.

PLUTO

No, it wasn't. They tried to humiliate me, but it won't work. This life is too good.

ERIS

But that's just it. It's only good if it's good for everyone.

PLUTO

That's stupid. Mom would be dead. Dad would be dead.

ERIS

I know.

PLUTO

Then what are you saying?

ERIS

I don't want to be digital.

PLUTO

Of course you do.

ERIS

No, I don't.

PLUTO

What do I need to do to convince you?

Eris thinks.

ERIS

Maybe talking with the protesters would help.

PLUTO

Why would I speak with violent terrorists?

ERIS

Because I need you to.

Pluto is silent - thinking.

ERIS (CONT'D)

What better way to help us understand?

Pluto is willing to listen to Eris now.

PLUTO

How?

Eris looks at the Officiant.

ERIS

If I have your permission, I could ask them to appear through the Officiant.

The Officiant isn't comfortable with the idea either.

OFFICIANT

I don't think we should be inviting terrorists into this body.

ERIS

I'm open to other ideas.

Pluto and the Officiant look at each other, thinking.

ERIS (CONT'D)

(To Pluto)

You both could make a backup right now. Then you'll be safe.

OFFICIANT

That's true.

ERIS

(To Pluto)

You wanted to use this ceremony to help people understand.

Eris acknowledges the audience.

ERIS (CONT'D)

This will work.

OFFICIANT

I'm in service to you, Pluto. I'll do as you wish.

Pluto hesitates - afraid.

CUT TO BLACK. SILENCE.

ACT 3, SCENE 3: ABSTRACT VIDEO

Abstract video plays on the projector screen. The Timeline displays "Year 2057".

While the video plays, stagehands bring a long table to the center stage.

They set plates of cake in front of two seats. Pluto's coffin with her body still remains upright behind the table.

In the abstract video, Saejin approaches a teenage Pluto.

PLUTO (V.O.)

Hey.

SAEJIN (V.O.)

Hello, I feel like we may have met before.

PLUTO (V.O.)

Uh, I guess? I don't meet a lot of people. Do you know my Dad? He's the rich guy going to space.

SAEJIN (V.O.)

I've heard of him. Are you enjoying the party?

Pluto is uncomfortable with the question.

PLUTO (V.O.)

Maybe. To be honest, I don't like people, especially people I only vaguely know. A bunch of them congratulated me for what Dad's doing. Like I had anything to do with it.

SAEJIN (V.O.)

What do you think of his mission?

PLUTO (V.O.)

It's amazing.

SAEJIN (V.O.)

I can tell you'd like to join him.

PLUTO (V.O.)

But I'm not digital.

CUT TO BLACK. SILENCE.

ACT 3, SCENE 4: DARKNESS

"Year 2381" is projected on the screen.

CASSI (V.O.)

Five...

ACT 3, SCENE 5: HOLLYWOOD FOREVER - MAIN CHAPEL

The lighting turns to Hollywood Forever lighting: 2.

No slide is projected. Ambient Protesters are heard (Underbed).

Eris pulls out the chair for Pluto. There is cake on the table.

ERIS

(to Pluto)

Will you do it?

The protesters grow louder.

PROTESTER (V.O.)

Down with the vampire class!

PLUTO

I'm not afraid of anyone or anything. Go ahead and invite them here.

Pluto takes her seat at the head of the table.

ERIS

Like the Officiant... wait.

(to Officiant)

What's your name?

OFFICIANT

I'm John-Mark.

Eris takes time to look at him.

ERIS

John-Mark... like the Gospel of Mark. Your name suits you. You're a kind and compassionate companion. Thank you for being patient with me.

OFFICIANT

I didn't have much choice.

ERIS

What's your last name?

OFFICIANT

Bernal.

ERIS

John-Mark Bernal. I'm sorry that I didn't see you sooner. You are the exact right person for this job.

(to Pluto)

Are you ready?

PLUTO

My mind is ready.

ERIS

"This is your last chance. After this, there is no turning back. You take the blue pill"!

Pluto smiles.

PLUTO

Red pill.

At the table, Eris ushers John-Mark to the empty seat.

ERIS

John-Mark, will you join us?

JOHN-MARK

I will. May my mechanical body be a vessel for Pluto to witness to the world.

John-Mark takes his seat at the table.

PROTESTER (V.O.)

Resist the algorithm!

ERIS

Thank you both for your courage. I'm going to talk with the protesters again and see if they'll join us.

Eris gets up to leave.

ERIS (CONT'D)

Oh, and while I'm gone, please enjoy the cake.

Eris exits. The sounds of protesters grow louder when she opens the door.

PROTESTER 2 (V.O.)

Nothing lasts forever!

ACT 3, SCENE 6: HOLLYWOOD FOREVER - MAIN CHAPEL

John-Mark and Pluto look at their plates of cake. They both have real cake in front of them, but both consume digital cake. John-Mark grabs a digital fork and brings a digital bite of cake to his mouth.

Ambient Protesters continue (Underbed). Hollywood Forever Lighting: 2 remains.

JOHN-MARK

(chews)

It's delicious.

Pluto takes a bite then turns to her Mom, who is now a ghost in the audience.

PLUTO

Mom, did you make this?

Pluto's Mom, Laura, responds from her front row seat in the audience, though the audience can only see her with a phone.

LAURA JONES (V.O.)

I did.

Pluto is unusually concerned.

PLUTO

What is it?

LAURA JONES (V.O.)

It's a tad unconventional, but it's my new favorite. I used roasted beets, ginger and coconut with a salted nut crumble topping for a caramel taste. Our good friend Oliver turned me on to it.

JOHN-MARK

It's lovely.

LAURA JONES (V.O.)

He'll be happy to hear that.

Pluto takes another bite, concerned.

PLUTO

I can't taste it.

LAURA JONES (V.O.)

Don't worry, darling, the taste should come soon enough.

That does not reassure Pluto.

CUT TO BLACK. SILENCE.

ACT 3, SCENE 7: DARKNESS

"Year 2381" is projected on the screen.

CASSI (V.O.)

Four...

ACT 4

ACT 4, SCENE 1: HOLLYWOOD FOREVER - MAIN CHAPEL

The lighting returns to Hollywood Forever lighting: 2.

No slide is projected. Ambient Protesters are heard (Underbed).

Eris comes back in.

ERIS

They've agreed to meet in digital form.

John-Mark gets distracted with an incoming message.

JOHN-MARK

DECENTRALIZED asked to join. I'm letting them in.

*John-Mark goes into a trance-like state and
DECENTRALIZED comes through his body. DECENTRALIZED
uses the Officiant's natural voice.*

DECENTRALIZED / OFFICIANT

We are DECENTRALIZED. We represent the people.

ERIS

Hello DECENTRALIZED. You deleted my sister once. If it happens again, I will hunt you down and destroy everything that you hold dear. You've been warned.

Pluto is surprised at her sister's words and is now less nervous.

ERIS (CONT'D)

Now, would you like a slice of cake?

DECENTRALIZED

That is very kind of you, yes.

Eris gets DECENTRALIZED a slice of cake.

PLUTO

Why are you here?

DECENTRALIZED / OFFICIANT

Over one billion people have died because of greed. We demand a right to life on this planet.

PLUTO

No one's denying you that.

DECENTRALIZED / OFFICIANT

Your entire family is denying us that right.

PLUTO

How?

DECENTRALIZED / OFFICIANT

By hoarding resources. You take for yourself, regardless of cost to others or the planet.

PLUTO

That's not true!

DECENTRALIZED / OFFICIANT

Have you ever had a dog?

PLUTO

No. What does a dog have to do with anything?

DECENTRALIZED / OFFICIANT

Well, most people who have a dog are stewards of that dog. They're responsible for the dog. They make sure that the dog can live as long as possible.

PLUTO

And if I had a dog, I'd make sure it did live as long as possible. My dog would have Life Extension, and would die when they choose.

DECENTRALIZED / OFFICIANT

How would you know when your dog wants to die?

PLUTO

The same way anyone knows. You have to make a choice. I permitted you here on my Ascension Day to challenge my ideas and sharpen my mind. If you continue to ask me such idiotic questions I'll have to end this conversation.

DECENTRALIZED

Go ahead. But you won't reach anyone.

PLUTO

That's fair. I do need the right people to understand me and join our movement.

DECENTRALIZED / OFFICIANT

Here we go: the "right people". And how does one become "right"?

PLUTO

By using Life Extension for more than the allotted three months, we're creating a revolution of abundance.

DECENTRALIZED / OFFICIANT

An abundant life does not mean an endless life.

PLUTO

Abundance means having more than you need. You can't have an abundant life until you have immortal life. When Saejin invented brain-scanning, she cured death. The cold hard truth of the matter is that some people, like her, deserve to live longer than others.

DECENTRALIZED / OFFICIANT

Like you swindling 10,000 years?

PLUTO

No.

DECENTRALIZED

Life Extension was set up so that every single person on the planet has access. And when you take more than your three months, that extra time is taken from someone else.

PLUTO

We take only what people willingly sell. And the system currently has a three month limitation, but there are people who will find ways to break those limitations. They'll find ways to surpass them, and then we can extend this Life Extension to everyone for e+ernity.

DECENTRALIZED

You fancy yourself a god?

PLUTO

Not a god. Just deserving.

DECENTRALIZED

What makes you more deserving than others?

PLUTO

Vision. I'm more deserving because I have vision.

CUT TO BLACK. SILENCE.

ACT 4, SCENE 2: ABSTRACT VIDEO

Abstract video plays on the projector screen. The Timeline displays "Year 2381".

LUTHER PRICE (V.O.)

Attention crew of the Sower, Captain Price speaking. It's been 316 years, and we're almost home. Look out any window and you'll see the beauty of the exoplanets that surround us. Locked on the horizon is our massive new sun, TRAPPIST 1. She'll never rise or set, so when we wake, we'll be welcomed by her purple reddish light. That is first of many wonders ahead of us, if we make it through.

I won't lie, landing won't be easy. It demands a leap of faith unlike any we've been asked to make before. We're going down unconscious, for good reason. If we attempt descent without shutting ourselves down, we risk quantum decoherence. It would scramble our personalities, change our core being, and splinter our minds.

That means we're going down blind. If our calculations are off, we could end up in permanent day, where the scorching heat could cause everything to fail at once. If we end up in permanent night, the freezing temperatures could cause a total power loss. Worst of all, if we breakup on atmospheric entry, our strangelet drive could consume the entire planet. You all know the risks. All of us survive or none of us do. That is the leap we face to take root among the stars!

ACT 4, SCENE 3: HOLLYWOOD FOREVER - MAIN CHAPEL

The lighting returns to Hollywood Forever lighting: 2.

No slide is projected. Ambient Protesters are heard (Underbed).

PLUTO

In your vision a homeless person, someone who has contributed nothing to society, in fact, someone who is only taken from society, someone not even in their right mind, maybe someone who abused drugs, this person deserves access to Life Extension, instead of giving the most gifted people in our society the ability to continue on and be productive for the world. Who knows what harm you're doing by denying these talented people access to the system?!

DECENTRALIZED / OFFICIANT

Don't you see how evil that is! Equal access means EVERYONE has a better future. What you're saying is that some people are superior to others.

PLUTO

That's exactly what I'm saying. Some people ARE superior to others. You can't say that someone like the President of the United States is inferior to someone who has contributed nothing to this world.

DECENTRALIZED / OFFICIANT

Contributions to this world are not the only or even the MOST important things. Life in and of itself is beautiful and mysterious, yet you reduce humans to what they produce. Life is not about production.

PLUTO

Yes, it is. You are not worth something unless you produce something great. Like my Dad.

DECENTRALIZED / OFFICIANT

Who rejected you.

PLUTO

No. He loves me.

(Her voice cracks)

And even though he doesn't agree with my choices, he's one of those people producing results. Making the world better. And what he's doing would not be possible without Life Extension. He must continue for as long as he needs until he's able to discover a new world for us to live on.

DECENTRALIZED / OFFICIANT

We've destroyed this planet because of that exact mindset. We thought that we could use every single resource on this planet to enrich our own lives at the cost of everyone else's. This world, our communities, our pets, they're not products. They're life itself. They are to be experienced, enjoyed, loved.

PLUTO

Are you seriously trying to tell me that the President is not better than drug addicts?

DECENTRALIZED / OFFICIANT

That's exactly what I'm saying. It's the President's job to serve the people, not to live forever at the expense of the people.

Anyone who's alive has the dignity of life. They have inherent value. An equal value. Because life is life, no matter what. And our goal should be for LIFE to carry on.

PLUTO

That's my goal.

Eris tries to lighten the conversation.

ERIS

"Life, uh... finds a way."

Pluto is annoyed.

ERIS (CONT'D)

I'll stop.

They keep on going.

PLUTO

I live for immortality. I live to bring the most productive and wonderful human beings life for as long as they can possibly stand it. I'm going to continue to fight for valuable people, like my Dad, to live forever.

DECENTRALIZED / OFFICIANT

I must care about the living, not the living dead. No single person should be able to take so much from the people here and now in the name of the future.

PLUTO

Are you okay with dying? What if you were to die tomorrow?

DECENTRALIZED / OFFICIANT

Of course I'm not okay with dying. It worries me. But I don't think there's value in living forever. We need people to come into the system with new ideas. We need change.

PLUTO

This is getting fun. At first I was afraid of this conversation, but this is good. This is hilarious actually. You're really going to argue in favor of death!?!

DECENTRALIZED / OFFICIANT

I am.

CUT TO BLACK. SILENCE.

ACT 4, SCENE 4: ABSTRACT VIDEO

Abstract video plays on the projector screen. The Timeline displays "Year 2065".

PLUTO (V.O.)

Are you sure you want to go through with all this planning for me?

ERIS (V.O.)

Yes! Are you kidding? This birthday is important to me.

PLUTO (V.O.)

But it's my birthday... not yours?

ERIS (V.O.)

Wow, shots fired. Alright, fair point. This is your day. I want you to be happy... Are you?

PLUTO (V.O.)

What?

Eris checks to see if Pluto is suicidal.

ERIS (V.O.)

Happy. I mean, nobody is jubilant 24/7, that would be delusional. But, like, generally, are you good?

Pluto deliberately misinterprets / misleads Eris.

PLUTO (V.O.)

I'm happier than I've ever been, Eris.

ACT 4, SCENE 5: HOLLYWOOD FOREVER - MAIN CHAPEL

The lighting returns to Hollywood Forever lighting.

No slide is projected. Ambient Protesters are heard (Underbed).

PLUTO

(laughs)

Go ahead. I'm listening. This should be really good.

DECENTRALIZED / OFFICIANT

Without death, there is no urgency.

PLUTO

Life Extension is urgent because we're going extinct.

DECENTRALIZED / OFFICIANT

That's bullshit. Look at the carbon footprint! Look at all the humans you rely on to fix you. You can see Life Extension is causing climate change.

PLUTO

No. Digital life is how we stop climate change.

DECENTRALIZED

You want to stop climate change with a fantasy, but we can only stop it with collective change. Collective change is how we make progress.

PLUTO

Let's talk about progress. I'm doing what's best for humanity as a whole. And even if the digital world is shallow now, someday it will be as rich as the physical world. In fact, it will even seem physical to us, the only difference is that we're able to choose what we suffer, what pain we experience, and we get to control when we die. How can this be bad? And how am I wrong for wanting this?

Eris interrupts.

ERIS

Why did you do it?

PLUTO

Oh.

(thinks)

Because I didn't want to suffer the heat, I didn't want to feel pain, and because it is more humane to be digital.

ERIS

But you lied to me.

PLUTO

Because you would have stopped me.

Pluto gets back to her philosophizing.

PLUTO (CONT'D)

Anything short of immortality is a cruel world.

DECENTRALIZED / OFFICIANT

Not cruel - immaterial, like you want. We must reorient our lives around the things that matter - things that are not things, but relationships, ideas, nature, community, and works that benefit the public good.

PLUTO

You're not a fool, but you're an idiot to turn down immortality.

DECENTRALIZED / OFFICIANT

Well this idiot thanks you for the cake.

ERIS

(To Decentralized)

Have you said everything you wished to say?

DECENTRALIZED / OFFICIANT

I have.

ERIS

And Pluto, do you wish to add anything?

PLUTO

Only this: What's better than a world we design ourselves?

CUT TO BLACK. SILENCE.

ACT 4, SCENE 6: DARKNESS

"Year 2381" is projected on the screen.

CASSI (V.O.)

Three...

ACT 5

ACT 5, SCENE 1: HOLLYWOOD FOREVER - MAIN CHAPEL

The lighting returns to Hollywood Forever lighting: 1.

No slide is projected. Ambient Protesters are heard (Underbed).

With the toll of a bell, DECENTRALIZED disappears and John-Mark returns to the robotic body.

JOHN-MARK

How was it?

PLUTO

DECENTRALIZED was a worthy opponent. Even so, I think I got the best of them. I'm pleased with how it went.

JOHN-MARK

Praise be.

PLUTO

I ran a trace on them to get their location. Please make sure to export your logs and report it to the police.

ERIS

Are the police really necessary?

PLUTO

Of course they are. We can't compromise the security of Life Extension. If anyone can access me, no one will be able to trust in e+ernity.

ERIS

And what if that's a good thing?

PLUTO

Stop! I need you on my side.

ERIS

The world we live in is beautiful. It's spontaneous. It's full of mystery. Personally, I would never want to live in a world of my own control.

PLUTO

Yes you would. Everyone would. The world will be exactly as you want it to be.

ERIS

I guess I think the world is good as it is.

PLUTO

Even as we face extinction?

ERIS

I don't believe that humans will go extinct.

CUT TO BLACK. SILENCE.

ACT 5, SCENE 2: ABSTRACT VIDEO

Abstract video plays on the projector screen. The Timeline displays "Year 2130".

Eris is now an old woman (91 years old).

ERIS (V.O.)

To my sister...

When Nio was born, Truth and I planted a garden at our home here in the Hollywood Hills. We had sunflowers, strawberries, cherry tomatoes, lettuce, you name it. One day, I stuck an artificial lily in the center. It reminded me of you. Over the years, Truth, Nio and I would go out to water the garden, but the lily never needed water.

We would stop and smell the sunflowers, don't ask me why, Nio loved that faint earthy smell. But we never smelled the lily. We cared for everything in that garden, except for the lily. Sure, sometimes the wind would knock it over, and we would have to pick it back up. After time, I noticed that the lily was frail. It too was worn out by the sun, the wind, the rain.

Below our home in the hills, I have a star on the Walk of Fame thanks to my work in *Saturn Before I Die* by the brilliant Mikos Zavros. He taught me that everything is temporary. Even you. That's why we need to take care of each other while we can.

When you get this, I'll be dead. But I keep that weathered lily with my Oscar. Nio promises that he and his kids will take care of it when I'm gone, until one day, maybe you'll make it back home. Please remember that wherever there's time, there's time to change.

ACT 5, SCENE 3: HOLLYWOOD FOREVER - MAIN CHAPEL

The lighting returns to Hollywood Forever lighting.

No slide is projected. Ambient Protesters are heard (Underbed).

Pluto is shook.

PLUTO

What do you mean you don't believe we'll go extinct? We've destroyed the planet. We're all dying! Extinction is almost certain.

ERIS

I don't believe that.

PLUTO

Why are you denying the reality in front of us?

ERIS

I'm not, I simply believe in our future.

PLUTO

But without Life Extension, we'd go extinct.

ERIS

Then we've already invented the solution.

PLUTO

But you don't want to live forever?

ERIS

No.

PLUTO

(hurt)

This just isn't my day.

ERIS

It's not my intention to hurt you.

PLUTO

That makes it even worse.

ERIS

Remember when DECENTRALIZED asked if you had a dog?

PLUTO

Yes, I hate dogs.

ERIS

You hate dogs named Pluto.

PLUTO

True.

ERIS

But that got me thinking. Dogs are trusting. A coyote will come up to a dog and pretend to play. Pretend or not, the dog is happy to play back! They will play and play until they reach the pack. Outnumbered, the dog gets devoured.

PLUTO

Beautiful story.

ERIS

Just wait. The dog trusts foolishly and sometimes she gets murdered. But she could get murdered anyway.

PLUTO

I'm not following.

ERIS

Coyotes aren't safe either. They're street smart. They spend their days figuring out how to survive. Dogs, on the other hand, are trusting. They live safe, leisurely lives. Dogs trust foolishly. Coyotes trust limitedly. But here's the interesting thing. Coyotes don't live as long as dogs... Do you know what that tells me?

PLUTO

No.

ERIS

If you want to live, trust foolishly!

PLUTO

And get burned?

ERIS

Maybe you'll get burned, maybe even killed, but you could either way.

(beat)

So who do you want to be? The dog or the coyote?

PLUTO

I want to be the coyote.

ERIS

And I want to be the dog.

John-Mark walks up.

JOHN-MARK

I've filed the police report. I believe we can move on with the ceremony.

ERIS

I love you, Pluto. I'm glad that you're here with us. I'll take you in digital form over extinction any day.

Eris takes her seat in the audience.

ACT 5, SCENE 4: HOLLYWOOD FOREVER - MAIN CHAPEL

Stagehands strike the table and the plates of cake.

No slide is projected. Ambient Protesters continue.

John-Mark rings the wind chime and takes a step forward.

JOHN-MARK

With this third and final stage, we call forth the future. The future is the idea that gives us hope. If it were to cease to exist, we would cease to dream.

As we celebrate the future, we acknowledge that endless possibilities bring uncertainty. However, we celebrate the certainty of the time remaining in our digital lives.

Thus we begin the transference of time.

Pluto, your three months began at your ascension. It is now customary to ask those in attendance if they would like to donate any of their after-time to your bank.

(addressing the audience)

You each have three months' time. Does anyone wish to give their time to Pluto's cause?

A coin appears on your phone app that allows you to transfer a custom amount to Pluto.

JOHN-MARK (CONT'D)

As Pluto has proved, your donation will not go to waste.

Eris hands John-Mark her three-month time coin.

ERIS

Pluto, I give all my time to you.

PLUTO

I don't want all of your time! I want you to join me!

ERIS

What if I gave some of my time to others?

PLUTO

Sure, the more who join us, the better! But I want you here.

ERIS

I'll think about it.

JOHN-MARK

Thank you both.

As we stated earlier, Pluto acquired 10,000 years of after time. She acquired it legally and in doing so, she helped many to prosper.

John-Mark goes over to Pluto's dead body, which has two coins covering her eyes. He removes them.

JOHN-MARK (CONT'D)

When I twist these coins together, this time will transfer to Pluto.

(beat)

Pluto, are you ready to receive your time?

CUT TO BLACK. SILENCE.

ACT 5, SCENE 5: DARKNESS

"Year 2381" is projected on the screen.

CASSI (V.O.)

Two...

ACT 5, SCENE 6: HOLLYWOOD FOREVER - MAIN CHAPEL

The lighting returns to Hollywood Forever lighting.

No slide is projected. Ambient Protesters are heard (Underbed).

Pluto stops him dramatically.

PLUTO

No. I'm not ready. Not yet.

Eris reacts.

PLUTO (CONT'D)

I had a dream for this day. I thought that it would be a gathering of my friends and family. A celebration of my life, and a celebration of my future. I thought that I could show you my passion for the digital world. I thought that you'd be moved. I thought that you would want to live forever. But I don't think all of you are convinced just yet. And the very purpose of this public Ascension ceremony is to show you just how great our future can be. So before I take my remaining time, I ask you to judge me. How much time do you want me to have?

Eris jumps up.

ERIS

Why are you doing this?

PLUTO

To show you that I'm not afraid of death.

ERIS

But you are afraid of death. We all are.

PLUTO

I'm not. I made it here. I self-terminated. And now I'm free. I have no fear.
So judge me. If 10,000 years isn't fair, what is?

ERIS

If they judge you, you could run out of time.

PLUTO

Maybe, but I need to know.
(to the audience)
Now judge me!

ERIS

(to the audience)
Be kind.

ACT 5, SCENE 7: HOLLYWOOD FOREVER - MAIN CHAPEL

The audience judges Pluto. Your screens display a sliding scale where you can decide how much time she has left. You slide it up or down.

While the audience is participating, stage hands strike the tables, podium, and casket from the stage.

PLUTO

John-Mark, will you tell me how much time I have left?

OFFICIANT
You have _____ left.

CUT TO BLACK. SILENCE.

ACT 5, SCENE 8: ABSTRACT VIDEO

Abstract video plays on the projector screen. The Timeline displays "Year 2381".

The ISC Sower prepares for landing.

LUTHER PRICE (V.O.)
This is it. This is the moment we've dreamed of.
We're about to land. As you know, it's our most dangerous step.
Before we go dark, there's one last thing:
It'll take 40 years for your messages to reach Earth.
Send them now.
Then hold steady. Our new home is waiting.

ACT 5, SCENE 9: VIDEO MESSAGE

Now the projector timeline displays "Year 2381".

Pluto, in uniform, walks on stage. She walks through the aisles as she speaks to the audience.

The lighting changes to Spaceship Lighting.

PLUTO
Greetings from Space. My name is Pluto Kennedy Price. As we take root among the stars, I find myself looking back. In 2065, people judged my actions. They were fair, and even kind, but I was cowardly and ran away so that I wouldn't run out of time. Maybe now I'm less afraid of my own end. I'm more afraid of life without people, like Dad. We made it this far together. And Eris. I miss her. If this journey has taught me anything, it's that there's always a countdown. Once my hardware breaks, I rely on strangers to fix me, which means that I only have time if people give it to me. Which they have. They've given me more time. Dad made sure of it. I don't actually belong here. But I don't want to die!

Pluto freezes in place.

CUT TO BLACK. SILENCE.

ACT 5, SCENE 10: FINAL COUNTDOWN

"Year 2381" is projected on the screen.

CASSI (V.O.)

One...

THE VIDEO AND LIGHTING DRAMATICALLY CUT TO BLACK.

END CREDITS ROLL AND END MUSIC PLAYS.

THE END.